

Cat & Company

Issue 4

24 pp

No More Nothing

David White

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Page 1

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg sits in the driver's seat of the **2018 Ford Focus** they've been loaned by the State of Oklahoma. **Penny Skragg** sits in the passenger seat, holding an M4A1 carbine. She's double-checking everything, trying to make sure it will work. The **2018 Ford Focus** is inside the "Civic Centre Parkade" (sic) at 550 W 3rd St.

Penny Skragg

I pressed the *forward assist*, and it's like nothing happened.

Camillo Skragg

I think it's *supposed* to do that.
You ready?

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg carefully points the carbine out of the car and tries to relax in the passenger seat.

Penny Skragg

Ask me once it's over.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg grabs the steering wheel and pulls himself up into a ready position.

Camillo Skragg

Yeah, no *shit*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A message is received on a smartphone in a stand on the dashboard. **Camillo Skragg** reads it and clears the notification.

Camillo Skragg

The *arraignment* is over.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg starts the engine of the **2018 Ford Focus**.

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg puts the **2018 Ford Focus** in "drive".

Camillo Skragg

They'll be out shortly.
Here we go.

Page 2

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **2018 Ford Focus** rolls down the spiral driveway with **Camillo Skragg** behind the wheel and **Penny Skragg** in the passenger seat.

Box (*FEMA Liaison, not visible*)

“Downtown’s been evacuated of *non-essential personnel*.”

Box (*Mayor of Tulsa, not visible*)

“We’ve loaned them a *surplus car* from the *Municipal fleet*.”

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The engine of the **2018 Ford Focus** idles as **Penny Skragg** moves to sit on the passenger-side door, holding the carbine; she will be firing over the roof of the car.

Box (*General of the Oklahoma National Guard, not visible*)

“Against my *better judgment*, we provided the Skraggs a *carbine* and some *ammunition*.”

“Evidently they want their *pound of flesh*.”

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

From left to right, **The Eye**, **Thresher**, and **Jolt** stand in front of the “Page Belcher Federal Building” entrance at 333 W 4th St.

The Eye

They’re— *letting us go*?

Thresher

Not exactly. We need to stick around for our *next court date*.

Jolt

I think “*Not Guilty*” was the right *plea*.

Victor was the one who *did the deed*.

Panel 4 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A view down W 4th St. The **2018 Ford Focus** speeds down the empty road, and **Penny Skragg** aims over the roof of the car. **The Eye** points vaguely in the direction of the oncoming car.

The Eye

Hey!

We’re in *dan*—

Page 3

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

The Eye is struck in the head by a bullet, dying instantly. **Jolt** and **Thresher** begin to react. Several other bullets strike the pavement, and one lodges in **Thresher's** armored body.

The Eye (dying)

ghhhh–

Title

No More Nothing

Panel 2 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg fires the carbine over the roof of the speeding **2018 Ford Focus**, while **Camillo Skragg** floors the accelerator.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt and **Thresher** run after the **2018 Ford Focus**, and prepare to take to the air.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jolt and **Thresher** fly after the **2018 Ford Focus** over W 4th St. **Penny Skragg** is back in the passenger seat and flips the safety on the carbine. **Camillo Skragg** is looking a little nervous.

Page 4**Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):**

Jinx Bubastis teleports onto **Thresher's** back with a shower of sparks. She holds on to his shoulders and stands on his back.

SF/X

VASSSP!

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat flies through the asphalt surface of W 4th St with a streak of smoke, and takes position behind **Jolt**. **Jolt** fires a lightning bolt from her right arm emitter at the **2018 Ford Focus** but misses. She is preparing to take another shot with the emitter on her left arm.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis snaps **Thresher's** neck. His mask flies off.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat channels a hellish blast of plasma into a tight shell around **Jolt**. Her body burns to ash in milliseconds.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis rides **Thresher's** corpse down to the pavement, and somersaults off his back as he skids to a stop on the street.

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Air resistance catches up to **Jolt**. Her body collapses into a cloud of ash. **Peter Cat** touches down near **Jinx Bubastis'** position.

Page 5

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat looks over at **Jinx Bubastis**. They are both realizing that it's over, for now.

Peter Cat

Target down.

Jinx Bubastis

Mine, too.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **2018 Ford Focus** has made a U-Turn on the empty W 4th St, and has stopped near **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis**. **Camillo Skragg** and **Penny Skragg** get out of the car. **Peter Cat** looks over at the humans.

Camillo Skragg (to Penny Skragg)

Are you shaking?

I'm shaking.

Penny Skragg

That means *we're not dead*.

Peter Cat

Let's get the *corpses* together.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close view of **Peter Cat**, who has a disturbingly neutral facial expression.

Peter Cat

I have enough *regard* for my *former colleagues* to not want to see them on a *dissection table*.
We'll *burn* the *bodies*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg looks horrified.

Penny Skragg

Dude...

I don't know *how to feel about that*.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg gestures towards the front of the courthouse.

Penny Skragg

Also, I kinda *domed* the Eye.

I think there're *bits of her head* all over the place.

Panel 6 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A close view of **Peter Cat**. He looks focussed, concentrating on the moment, getting an unpleasant job done.

Peter Cat

I'll have to do clean-up anyway.

Broken glass, bullets, cartridge casings.

Let's get to *work*.

Page 6

Panel 1 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

The **Crisis Center**; we finally see the people who were talking into boxes in the last few pages. **Jake Lyon** sits next to **The Magister** at the conference table.

Jake Lyon

Let's *pretend* I'm OK with the *Vlad Tepes* logic of putting *Honor Guard's heads on stakes*...
...how are we going to explain it to *the American people*?

The Magister

Poochie.

Jake Lyon

What!?

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jake Lyon looks at **The Magister** with obvious disbelief. **The Magister** keeps talking.

The Magister*

"They died on the way back to their home planet."

Jake Lyon

"The Simpsons"? *Really*?

The Magister*

Look at it from a *historic perspective*.

The *primary sources* are limited. All we need to do add enough *deliberate inconsistencies* to keep the *scholars* and *prodromal schizophrenics* busy.

You *act like truth matters*.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jake Lyon looks at **The Magister** with open astonishment. **The Magister** looks at the doorway and smiles at what he sees.

Jake Lyon

It *doesn't*?

The Magister*

You're very *clever*, you must have *noticed* by now.

I see the *hunters* have returned.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** enter the **Crisis Center**. They look a little tired.

Peter Cat

We stopped by the *police morgue* before coming here.

Jinx can tell you more.

Jinx Bubastis

The police guarding *Honor Guard's shuttle* were killed by a particularly *invasive* mind probe.

That's more *Demonlayer* than *Victor Bravo*.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jake Lyon seems relieved to talk about relatively real things.

Jake Lyon

RVS Tulsa ATC said they lost track of the shuttle after a couple of sweeps.
Is it *stealth*?

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis looks thoughtful.

Jinx Bubastis

If it's using *shields*, it's the *opposite* of stealth.
This is another piece of evidence that *Demonlayer* has taken the shuttle.
I think we can *eliminate* a possible *orbital* flight.
We need to *investigate the landing site*.

Page 7

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The bottom of the **Corporate escape pod**. **Victor Bravo** has survived a transcontinental flight on the outside of the pod, and is still clinging to the shuttle – barely.

Box (Jake Lyon, *not visible*)

What about *Victor Bravo*?

He's still *out there*, right?

Panel 1a (*small square inset*):

Victor Bravo's hand slips – he has lost his grip.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo falls. He's not unconscious, but he's not able to react right now.

Box (Jinx Bubastis, *not visible*)

If we are *very lucky* Demonslayer *killed* him.

I doubt it, though. She'd have made a *spectacle* of it.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo lands in a lake. It's Center Lake, in the Whittier Narrows Recreation area. The impact should be lethal, and probably would be if he weren't an alien super-soldier.

Box (Peter Cat, *not visible*)

Jinx is right.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Unfortunately, the fall and impact were not lethal. **Victor Bravo** crawls onto the shore.

Box (Peter Cat, *not visible*)

Victor Bravo is still a *threat*.

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The **Corporate escape pod** keeps flying over Montebello, and approaches downtown Los Angeles.

Killotron (*from inside pod*)

A landscape gnarled with alien breath,

We're cloaked in silence, veiled from their gaze.

Mistress' hand weaves the void's dark thread–

The primitives' radio beams – blind to our threat.

Demonslayer (*from inside pod*)

"Alien breath?"

Really, Killotron?

This *obscene sprawl* looks like a *tumor* to me.

Page 8

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Near sundown, a view from slightly above the parking lot of the Tulsa Expo Center, where the **Corporate escape pod** landed. It's been marked off with crime scene tape. **Jinx Bubastis** approaches the middle of the side. **Peter Cat**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** follow close behind.

Box (narration, upper left)

A little later, at the *landing site*...

Jinx Bubastis

The problem with *psychometry* is that the *impressions* become *unstuck in time*.

Of course *Victor Bravo* was here.

He flew the shuttle when it landed.

I couldn't tell you if he *came back*, it all *blends together*.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis kneels and closes her eyes, gesturing with one hand to feel the impressions.

Jinx Bubastis

I can feel *Bearcat*...

...and I can feel *Bearcat seeing Killotron*...

...where is *she*?

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis reacts as if she got an electric shock.

Jinx Bubastis (shouting in pain)

AH--!!

Peter Cat (off-panel)

Jinx!?

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis pulls back her hand. **Peter Cat** stands behind her, concerned.

Jinx Bubastis

A *ward*.

A *hex* on this place.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis looks concerned. **Peter Cat** turns to think a little.

Jinx Bubastis

Now I *know* she was here—

—but *she* knows we're on this planet!

Panel 6 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height):

Peter Cat approaches **Jinx Bubastis** and smiles a little.

Peter Cat

Excellent.

That means she knows we have the *only way off this rock*.

That means *leverage*.

Page 9

Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Nighttime on Radio Hill in Elysium Park, a location near Downtown Los Angeles. The area is largely inhabited by the homeless. **Bearcat** and **Killotron** have been sent to clear an encampment near where **Demonlayer** has set up her base; she is planning on using the antenna here in the near future. A close-up of a woman's face, illuminated by a nearby fire. The last few years of her life has not been kind to her. Half of her face is splattered with blood. She wants to scream, but cannot.

Box (*narration, upper left*)

Near Downtown L.A. is an abandoned place called *Radio Hill*.

Bearcat (*off-panel*)

The *female*!

There!

Box (*narration, lower right*)

The *desperate* use it as a *place of refuge*.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Killotron has one of his arm-mounted laser cannon extended, and fires at a target off-panel. **Bearcat** takes a child-like joy at **Killotron's** destruction of the target. The camp has been wrecked; tents burn.

SF/X (*near Killotron's laser cannon*)

FWEEEE!

SF/X (*off-panel, from the target of Killotron's laser cannon*)

SPLORT!!

Bearcat

Hah!

Well *done*, Killotron!

The area is secured!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Bearcat looks thoughtful as he speaks to **Killotron**. **Killotron** listens closely.

Bearcat

It is *fortunate* that Mistress has found a way home.

It is *unfortunate* that this makes me ask a *disturbing question*.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Bearcat continues talking to **Killotron**.

Bearcat

Was she prepared to *sacrifice us both*?

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Bearcat and **Killotron** turn to look at the lights of Downtown Los Angeles, illuminated from behind by small fires. **Bearcat** ponders.

Killotron

My beam carved art from ash and bone,
A symphony of smoke and flame.
Comrade's eyes, once wild, now gleam—
A mind forged in her silent name.
You whisper doubt, a blade unsharpened:
“Does she carve our fate into the void?”
Yet in her gaze, a star's slow burn—
A reckoning born where shadows roil.

Bearcat

It is *good* to see her *functioning* again.
I believe this is going to work.

Page 10

Panel 1 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Inside the **Crisis Center**, **Jinx Bubastis** hands out small devices – **neurocomms** – to **Peter Cat**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg**. **Peter Cat** puts his behind his ear. **Camillo Skragg** looks at his with some curiosity. **Penny Skragg** also puts hers behind her right ear.

Jinx Bubastis (to Camillo Skragg)

Here, take this.

Camillo Skragg

What is it?

Jinx Bubastis (to Camillo Skragg)

It's a *neurocomm* – a *neural interface* attached to a tiny *interocitor*.

There's software that lets you *stream* sensory inputs, too.

Panel 2 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks at **Camillo Skragg**. **Camillo Skragg** looks through a semi-transparent image of what **Penny Skragg** sees. **Jinx Bubastis** looks at this with mild amusement.

Camillo Skragg

Whoa.

Penny Skragg

See? This is what *I* see.

Camillo Skragg

Neat!

Jinx Bubastis

Since we're doing *counter-insurgency* now, we're going to need good coordination and mobility.

These should help a lot, especially if we have to split up.

Panel 3 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

The **DHS Liaison** is talking on her smartphone. She gestures towards **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg**, getting their attention.

DHS Liaison (into smartphone)

So, it's a *confirmed* sighting?

Let me put you on *speakerphone*.

Panel 4 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

The **DHS Liaison** puts her smartphone on the conference table. **Jinx Bubastis'** eyes glow as she telepathically makes contact with the caller.

Smartphone (Dispatch officer)

Hello! This is the East LA Sheriff's Department. As I was saying, we have reports of a *seven-foot cat-man* in Whittier and Montebello. eep!

Jinx Bubastis (word of power)

Pardon me, I need to *see through your eyes*.

We'll be right there.

Panel 5 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

An office in the **East LA Sheriff's Department**. **Peter Cat**, **Jinx Bubastis**, **Camillo Skragg**, and **Penny Skragg** appear in a shower of sparks. The **Dispatch officer** is shocked by their sudden appearance; she is looking directly at the space where they appear.

Dispatch officer

Yikes!

Jinx Bubastis

So, you were *saying*?

Panel 6 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Jinx Bubastis talks to the **Dispatch officer**. In the background, a **Radio operator** tries to get their attention.

Dispatch officer

Right... Our best guess is that he'll be heading to *Whittier Boulevard*.

Radio operator

Hey! *KJC625* just went down.
That's the LAPD's station.

Page 11

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer appears on every screen; her voice emerges from every speaker.

Demonlayer (TV)

Ape creatures! Please attend carefully.

You are in *mortal danger*.

I have hidden *several powerful bombs* in different locations.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis makes a “shoo” gesture to **Peter Cat**. **Peter Cat** leaves behind a smoky streak as he flies through the ceiling. **Demonlayer** continues her address.

Demonlayer (TV)

If *one* is tampered with, *all* will explode.

If *any* attempt to approach my position on *Radio Hill* is made, *all* will explode.

Any attempt to intervene, and I will *immediately* trigger detonation.

Jinx Bubastis (to Peter Cat)

Get out before she *detects* you!

Peter Cat (speech balloon trailing flight path)

On it!

Panel 3 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer keeps talking.

Demonlayer (TV)

Others of our kind are on your world!

One has a *starship*.

She will bring that ship to *Radio Hill*.

Radio operator

How is she *transmitting*—?

Jinx Bubastis (to Radio operator)

Sympathetic magic.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer ends her speech.

Demonlayer (TV)

One way or another, the bombs *will* explode.

Your *city* is forfeit.

You may *panic* now.

Panel 5 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Camillo Skragg turns around suddenly. The **Radio operator** talks to him, pointing at the exit.

Camillo Skragg

Wait a minute...

...where's *Penny*?

Radio operator

I think she went down to the *motor pool*.

Panel 6 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg speeds out of the motor pool on a police motorcycle. **Camillo Skragg** calls after her from an open window.

SF/X (Penny Skragg's motorcycle)

VROOM!

Camillo Skragg

Penny! *Wait!*

Page 12

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg takes a broad right turn onto Whittier Blvd on her “borrowed” police motorcycle.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg stands on the saddle of the motorcycle as she bears down on a running **Victor Bravo**.

Panel 2a (*small square inset*)

Penny Skragg firmly grabs the left, front brake of the motorcycle, causing the front wheel to jam.

Panel 3 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Penny Skragg is launched into a high arc over **Victor Bravo** and turns as she somersaults; she will land facing him once he gets up. The police motorcycle also somersaults, in a lower arc that catches **Victor Bravo** in the back and slams him into the pavement.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo recovers quickly and gets to his feet, seemingly uninjured. **Penny Skragg** lands in a ready stance.

Panel 5 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Victor Bravo lowers into a crouch to charge at **Penny Skragg**. **Penny Skragg** make a “bring it” gesture with one hand.

Victor Bravo

Is this some kind of joke?

Page 13

Note: All continuity issues are intentional. Penny's a reality warper, bullshit is her weapon. It should look at least superficially plausible.

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo lunges forwards, a comically large plastic (but very, very sharp) combat knife in his right hand. He is attempting to decapitate **Penny Skragg** with a single swing. **Penny Skragg** ducks down deep and performs a Bruce Lee-style leg sweep.

Panel 2 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg's right arm hooks around **Victor Bravo's** extended right arm, like she performed an improbably quick roll after knocking **Victor Bravo's** foot out from under him.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg crouches, with the knife in her hand. In the background, **Victor Bravo** recovers very quickly, getting his feet back under him in a crouched stance, with his back to **Penny Skragg**.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width, 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg slams the knife hilt-deep into **Victor Bravo's** grotesquely muscled left thigh.

Victor Bravo (shout of pain)

GRAGH!

Panel 5 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo looks down at the knife hilt embedded into the outside of his left thigh. In the background, **Penny Skragg** sprints towards the locked gate covering the front door of a vacant building.

Panel 6 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo returns the bloody blade into the scabbard on his right boot. His gaze is fixated on the still-closed gate, which rattles a little after **Penny Skragg** somehow entered the vacant building.

Page 14

Note: All continuity issues are intentional. Penny's a reality warper, bullshit is her weapon. It should look at least superficially plausible.

Panel 1 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo smashes through the front door of the vacant building, breaking the gate and door frame into pieces, tearing out bits of wall.

Panel 2 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Light streams into the darkened interior of the vacant building through the open back door. **Victor Bravo** charges forward towards it.

Panel 3 (1/3rd page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo face-plants just outside the back door. Behind him is a crude set of stairs made of cinder blocks.

Panel 4 (1/3rd page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo looks back at the staircase; it should be six blocks in a 3-2-1 configuration, but the bottom step is missing.

Panel 5 (1/3rd page width. 1/3rd page height):

The missing cinder block impacts the top of **Victor Bravo's** head, shattering.

Panel 6 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo flies up to the roof using his jetpack.

Panel 7 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo has landed on the roof. He reaches for his side-arm, and looks down to confirm that it's missing from its holster.

Page 15

Note: All continuity issues are intentional. Penny's a reality warper, bullshit is her weapon. It should look at least superficially plausible.

Panel 1 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg lifts **Victor Bravo's** oversized sidearm to aim it at **Victor Bravo's** solar plexus. **Victor Bravo** stands there, slack-jawed.

Panel 2 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

A laser blast strikes **Victor Bravo's** body armor; there is a small explosion of sparks.

SF/X ZZAP

Victor Bravo (grunt of pain) gnnh...

Panel 3 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Much like Panel 2. **Penny Skragg** has found the second trigger, and has fired a miniature explosive shell into **Victor Bravo's** solar plexus. There is a muffled explosion.

SF/X (muffled explosion) THOMP

Panel 4 (Half page width. 1/3rd page height):

Victor Bravo falls to his knees. He has been disemboweled inside his body armor. Blood is already starting to pool around his knees.

Victor Bravo (dying)

It's... cold...

Panel 5 (Full page width. 1/3rd page height):

Penny Skragg looks on in horror as **Victor Bravo** falls face-first onto the roof of the vacant building. **Victor Bravo** bleeds out.

Victor Bravo (dying)

Whyzit...

...col-

Box (lower right, Penny Skragg, neurocomm)

"Victor Bravo's down."

Page 16

Panel 1 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*):

A large monitor inside the **Crisis Center** shows news footage from a helicopter of the roof in East LA where **Victor Bravo** died. **Penny Skragg** is curled up into a ball and is barely visible. **Victor Bravo's** corpse lies prone in a large pool of blood. The **Mayor of Tulsa** stares at the monitor; he is feeling both triumph and horror. **Jake Lyon** is cradling his head. **The Magister** is sitting next to him, watching events unfold with a slight smile. Several other figures are clapping in the foreground.

Mayor of Tulsa (*under his breath*)

Got the fucker...

Jake Lyon (*exhausted*)

It's not over yet.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jake Lyon turns to **The Magister**.

The Magister

No, it isn't.

But it's only a matter of time.

Jake Lyon

You're confident.

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

Jake Lyon tries to stare down **The Magister**, who does not respond.

Jake Lyon

I know *journalists*.

I can tell them the *truth*.

Then what would you do?

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Magister gets up from the table and smiles at **Jake Lyon**.

The Magister

I hope you weren't expecting some kind of *theatrical threat*.

Panel 5 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*):

The Magister's back as he heads for the door to the **Crisis Center**.

The Magister

We all do what we must.

Page 17

Panel 1 (Full page width, 1/3rd page height)

Mid-morning. **Peter Cat** hovers above LA at the edge of space.

Peter Cat (neurocomm)

I seem to be far enough away that *Demonlayer* can't sense me.
But I'm *close enough* that I *could* neutralize the *bombs*.

Panel 2 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Camillo Skragg holds **Penny Skragg** in the **East LA Sheriff's Department**.

Camillo Skragg (neurocomm)

Penny's back.
She seems to be OK.

Panel 3 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

The **Radio operator** talks to **Jinx Bubastis**, and offers her an inexpensive aircraft radio.

Radio operator

The *airspace* over LA is *restricted* – you'll need to talk to ATC.

Jinx Bubastis

Gotcha. Do you have a summary of the procedures?

Radio operator

Yeah, over here.

Panel 4 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Peter Cat hovers above LA at the edge of space.

Peter Cat (neurocomm)

I haven't been able to locate the *bombs* yet.
The *signal* is weak, and there's a *lot* of noise.

Panel 5 (Half page width, 1/3rd page height)

Camillo Skragg thinks for a moment, and has an idea.

Camillo Skragg (neurocomm)

Wait a minute. The bombs use *antimatter*, right?
Even a *tiny leak* would produce *gamma radiation*!

Page 18**Panel 1 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)**

Camillo Skragg talks on his smartphone.

Camillo Skragg

Hello? Professor?

Yes, it's me, Camillo.

Panel 2 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Camillo Skragg sits down and keeps talking.

Camillo Skragg

I'd need a big favor from you – could you have the Fermi Gamma-ray Space Telescope image the LA Basin?

You can do it now?

Great!

Panel 3 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Camillo Skragg seems palpably relieved. He hangs up.

Camillo Skragg

Thanks, you're a real life-saver.

Panel 4 (*Half page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Camillo Skragg downloads the image onto his smartphone.

Camillo Skragg (*neurocomm*)

Peter?

Are you seeing this?

Panel 5 (*Full page width, 1/3rd page height*)

Peter Cat looks through a translucent neurocomm projection of the image from the Fermi gamma-ray telescope.

Peter Cat (*neurocomm*)

Excellent.

Yes, this helps.

I can locate the bombs.

Page 19

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

The cockpit of the **Black Sabbath**. **Jinx Bubastis** operates an inexpensive aircraft radio (similar to a Garmin 115) that has been duct-taped to one of the consoles.

Jinx Bubastis

LAX Tower, Black Sabbath Niner Niner X-Ray, at two thousand seven hundred, request clearance en route to Radio Hill.

LAX ATC (*from radio*)

Black Sabbath Niner Niner X-Ray, maintain two thousand seven hundred,

Jinx Bubastis

Maintain two thousand seven hundred, wilco. Black Sabbath Niner Niner X-Ray.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat hangs on the edge of space above the Los Angeles Basin. He is concentrating intensely.

Peter Cat (*neurocomm*)

Good.

I have all ten bombs.

Isolating.

Panel 3 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis turns to the miniature gunnery station next to the cockpit. A view of the Radio Hill transmitter is on the screen. She has moved a targeting reticle to the building using a small joystick.

Peter Cat (*neurocomm*)

Isolated.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis looks at the covered arming switch for the **Black Sabbath's** nose-mounted deck gun. It remains unarmed.

Panel 5 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

The **Black Sabbath** lands near the entrance to the transmitter building. **Bearcat** and **Killotron** are standing watch outside the front door.

Page 20

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Bearcat opens the door to let **Jinx Bubastis** in. **Killotron** has a laser cannon extended, and is closely following **Jinx Bubastis'** movements.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer turns to face **Jinx Bubastis**. She is holding a **detonator**.

Demonlayer

So, you came.

You know, I could use a new *Number Six*—

Jinx Bubastis (*interrupting Demonlayer*)

No.

Panel 3 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer turns around to face **Jinx Bubastis**, with the **floating sphere** behind her.

Demonlayer

You brought your vessel?

Jinx Bubastis

Yes.

Come and *take* it.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer gives **Jinx Bubastis** a hard look. **Jinx Bubastis** does not react.

Panel 5 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Demonlayer waves one hand and gives an order. **Bearcat** and **Killotron** close in on **Jinx Bubastis**.

Demonlayer

Kill her.

Page 21

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis has telepathically reached deep into **Bearcat's** mind; her words are **Words of Power**.

Jinx Bubastis (*Words of Power*)

Your mind was *never* your own.
You were *always* a pet.
Your *life* was a lie.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Bearcat reels, his face distorted with despair. **Jinx Bubastis** jumps forwards and removes **Killotron's** head with an uppercut.

Panel 3 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Killotron staggers back, trying to aim his laser cannon blind. **Bearcat** puts a pistol to his own head.

Killotron

No light through shattered lenses—
Yet my circuits hum with unyielding fire.
Your fist a storm, your breath a blade,
I'll carve your name in static—

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis shatters the crystal on **Killotron's** chest.

SF/X (*from behind Jinx Bubastis, Bearcat shoots himself in the head off-panel*)

BLAM!

Panel 5 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

A ghostly wisp escapes from **Killotron's** inert body. **Jinx Bubastis** speaks **Words of Power** with a sad look.

Jinx Bubastis (*Words of Power*)

Be free now.

Page 22

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis snatches the **detonator** from **Demonlayer**'s hand. **Demonlayer** is having difficulty processing what is happening.

Jinx Bubastis

No speech.
No wizards' duel.

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis depresses the plunger of the **detonator** while flipping off **Demonlayer**. **Demonlayer** is illuminated from behind by a light like a flashbulb, and not the detonation she was expecting.

Jinx Bubastis

No *suicide bomb*.

Panel 3 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis holds **Demonlayer** by the neck. She seems to be consuming a glowing smoky mass coming from **Demonlayer**' head. **Jinx Bubastis** eats **Demonlayer**'s soul.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Another realm. At the shores of the **Lake of Fire**, **Demonlayer** screams as **Jinx Bubastis** pins her arms behind her back and prepares to give her a shove.

Panel 5 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

A view of the **Lake of Fire**. **Jinx Bubastis** has just pushed **Demonlayer** over the edge. You can get a good reference for how this should look from a Jack Chick tract.

Page 23

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Early afternoon. **Peter Cat** touches down next to the landed **Black Sabbath**.

Box (*narration, upper left*)

Later...

Peter Cat

Jinx?
Are you OK?

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Peter Cat walks into the building, and is startled at the sight of **Bearcat's** body on the floor. In the foreground, **Jinx Bubastis** sits in the Hunters' Repose position and tries to clear her mind.

Peter Cat

Penny's with Camillo, and doing all right.
I see—
—oh. Oh, crap.

Jinx Bubastis

I know this is going to sound like an excuse,
but I didn't *force* him to pull the trigger.

Panel 3 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jinx Bubastis has walked up to **Peter Cat**, who is now holding her.

Jinx Bubastis

I pushed a *cruel idea* into his mind, and *something gave way*.
Bearcat was a smart guy.
He had years of *fears* and *doubts* and *nobody to talk to*.

Peter Cat

He probably *knew* one of the *bombs* was here.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

A close view of **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis**.

Peter Cat

I guess no one is innocent.

Panel 5 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

A view a bit later, in front of the landed **Black Sabbath**. **Peter Cat** and **Jinx Bubastis** watch a funeral pyre in silence, huddled together.

Page 24

Panel 1 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Nighttime. An exterior view of a nice apartment in Georgetown, Washington, DC. Though the window, a telephone can be heard ringing. It's a smartphone, lying on the kitchen table.

Box (*narration, upper left*)

That evening, in Washington, DC...

Panel 2 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

A woman – **Image**, of the **Ready Men** – observes the telephone continuing to ring. She is unscrewing a silencer from the end of a Colt 1911 style .45 pistol. She looks down at the ground.

Panel 3 (*Full page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Jake Lyon lies dead on the floor of his kitchen. **Image** looks at him evenly, and sends a message through the **World of Ash**.

Image (*Words of Power*)

Teacher.
The work is done.

Voice (*Words of Power via the World of Ash*)

Then go.
We will handle the rest.

Panel 4 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Image disappears, leaving only a whiff of ectoplasm.

Panel 5 (*Half page width. 1/3rd page height*):

Nighttime, in the kitchen of **Jake Lyon's** Georgetown apartment, in the dark.